

OpenClaw Tui Interaction

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1. Course Content

Course Overview

OpenClaw TUI (Terminal User Interface) is a terminal-based text interaction interface. Without a graphical desktop environment, you can directly chat with the OpenClaw robot in the command line. TUI interaction is especially suitable for scenarios where you connect to the robot remotely via SSH and perform pure text interaction in the terminal.

Learning Objectives

- Master the method to start a terminal interaction session via the `openclaw tui` command
- Learn advanced usage of starting TUI with parameters
- Be familiar with common chat commands (slash commands) in TUI terminal
- Be able to troubleshoot and resolve common errors during TUI usage

2. Opening TUI Dialogue

Applicable Scenarios

TUI dialogue is mainly applicable to the following scenarios:

- **SSH Remote Connection** — After logging into the robot remotely via SSH, you can directly perform text interaction with OpenClaw in the terminal
- **Lightweight Interaction** — Compared with Web UI, TUI uses fewer resources and starts faster, suitable for quick debugging and daily use

Enter the following command directly in the terminal to start the TUI dialogue interface:

```
openclaw tui
```

```
session agent:main:main
gateway connected | idle
agent main | session main (openclaw-tui) | bailian/qwen3.6-plus | tokens 0/1.0m (0%)
```

[!NOTE]

- You can chat with the robot by typing text like in WebChat
- As long as the session ID is the same, dialogue history is synchronized between WebChat and TUI

3. Common TUI Terminal Chat Commands

- Chat commands in TUI terminal are exactly the same as slash commands in WebChat, and the usage method is also identical. All commands must start with `/` and be sent as **standalone messages**

```
session agent:main:main
connected | idle
agent main | session main (openclaw-tui) | bailian/qwen3.6-plus | tokens 0/1.0m (0%)

/

→ help          Show slash command help
status          Show gateway status summary
agent           Switch agent (or open picker)
agents          Open agent picker
session         Switch session (or open picker)
(1/55)
```

4. Common Errors and Solutions

4.1 Invalid API

Phenomenon: After sending a message, the robot prompts API-KEY invalid, authentication failed, or returns 401 error.

Possible Causes and Solutions:

- **API-KEY configuration error** — Check if the API-KEY configuration item in `openclaw.json` is correct, restart the gateway after reconfiguring
- **API-KEY expired** — Go to the model service provider's platform to check if the API-KEY has expired, regenerate a new KEY and update the configuration
- **Model service provider address error** — Confirm the API address (base URL) corresponding to the model in `openclaw models list` is filled correctly

```
# view current model configuration
openclaw models list
# view model status
openclaw models status
```

4.2 Model Quota Exceeded

Phenomenon: After sending a message, the prompt shows model call quota limit reached (Rate Limit / Quota Exceeded), or returns 429 status code.

Possible Causes and Solutions:

- **Quota exhausted** — Model service providers have daily/hourly call frequency or Token limits for free/trial accounts, please check account quota status
- **Multi-session concurrent consumption** — Having multiple sessions open simultaneously for parallel conversations will accelerate quota consumption,建议减少并发会话数量
- **Switch model** — If the current model quota is limited, you can use the `/model` command to switch to another configured model to continue the conversation

4.3 Gateway Not Running

Phenomenon: After executing `openclaw tui`, the prompt shows unable to connect to Gateway, connection refused, or stuck in connecting state for a long time.

Possible Causes and Solutions:

- **Gateway not started** — Start the Gateway service first:

```
openclaw gateway start
# Or use foreground running mode
openclaw gateway run
```

- **Gateway stopped or crashed** — Check Gateway running status and restart:

```
openclaw gateway status
openclaw gateway restart
```

- **Port occupied** — The default Gateway port is occupied by another program, check port occupancy:

```
# Check if default port 18789 is occupied
lsof -i :18789
```

4.4 Session Exception or Freezing

Phenomenon: TUI interface not responding, no return after sending a message for a long time, or interface displaying abnormally.

Possible Causes and Solutions:

- **Model response timeout** — Use the `/stop` command to stop the currently generating response, then resend the message
- **Terminal window size issue** — Adjust the terminal window size and re-execute the command, some terminal windows may cause display issues if too small
- **Session context too long** — Use `/compact` to compact session context and release Token space
- **Restart TUI** — Press `Ctrl+C` to exit TUI, then re-execute `openclaw tui` to start